

Forests and Woodlands



A HUGE EXPANSE OF evergreen forest stretches right across Canada, in a broad belt up to 500 miles (800 km) wide. It is sometimes called the boreal forest—after Boreas, the Greek god of the North Wind. The cones, buds, and needles of conifer trees provide food for a

variety of birds, such as grosbeaks, juncos, and crossbills. But the weather is bitterly cold in winter, and many birds fly south to escape the harsh climate.

To the south of these dark forests are areas of woodland where the climate is warmer and moister. The most common trees are broad-leaved species, such as oak, maple, walnut, and hickory, which lose their leaves in winter. The carpet of decaying leaves is full of insects that birds can feed on. There is also a greater variety of nesting places in these sunlit woodlands than in the dark conifer forests further north.

Yellow-bellied sapsucker

The yellow-bellied sapsucker drills neat rows of holes in trees, such as birches, and waits for the sap to ooze out and run down the trunk. Then it laps up the sugary sap with its brushlike tongue. Insects sometimes get trapped in the sticky liquid and the sapsucker eats these as well. In winter, the yellow-bellied sapsucker migrates south to the warmer climates of Central America and the Caribbean islands.

Yellow-bellied sapsucker
(*Sphyrapicus varius*)
Length: 8 in (21 cm)

Northern bobwhite
(*Colinus virginianus*)
Length: 11 in (28 cm)

Fish such as salmon are a common source of food for the eagle.



The maple trees of broad-leaved woodlands turn spectacular shades of red and gold before losing their leaves for the winter.

If a covey is disturbed, the birds fly off in different directions to confuse enemies and give the birds time to escape.



Northern bobwhite

Outside the breeding season, bobwhites gather in groups of 15 to 30 birds, called coveys. Each covey defends its own special area from other coveys. At night, a covey huddles on the ground in a circle. The birds sit with their heads pointing outward to face danger and their bodies touching to keep warm.

Bald eagle

The national bird of the United States, the bald eagle has a spectacular courtship display. A male and a female bird lock talons and somersault through the air. The pair make a gigantic nest called an eyrie. It is built in a tree or on a rocky cliff and made of sticks, weeds, and soil. The birds use the nest year after year and keep adding to it.

The white feathers on its head are fully visible by the time the bird is four years old.

Bald eagle
(*Haliaeetus leucocephalus*)
Length: 3 ft 2 in (96 cm)
Wingspan: up to 8 ft (2 m 40 cm)

